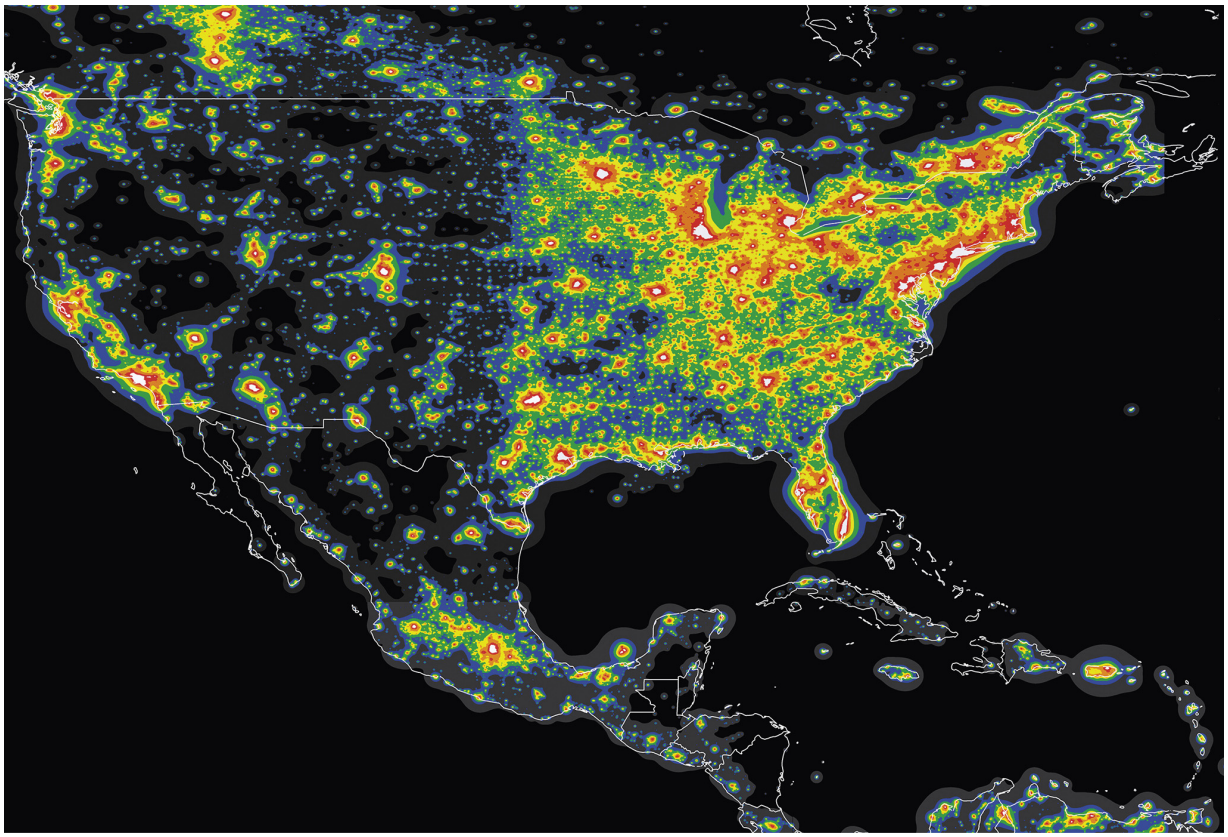


A map of light pollution across North America (white and red indicate where it is highest, black where it is lowest) explains why 99 percent of Americans cannot see the Milky Way.

“Dark areas are being lost in places where nocturnal animals, insects, and plants have adapted to darkness over billions of years.”

Franz Hölker

Vicious circle

Light pollution also has a detrimental effect on animals. Lights on tall towers, for example, draw migrating birds, causing them to crash into the towers and into power lines. Artificial light can also damage birds’ immune systems. Studies have found that house sparrows infected with the West Nile virus carried the virus twice as long when kept under dim light than